

health insurance (or coming directly off of your parents' coverage), any waiting periods probably will not apply to you, thanks to the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act of 1996 (HIPAA). The Department of Labor has created a good overview of how this works; take a look at www.dol.gov/ebsa/faqs/faq_consumer_hipaa.html.

- **Find out the cost of covering pregnancy.** If you're considering having a baby within the next couple of years, find out about maternity benefits and pediatric care. Many managed care plans offer attractive deals. There is usually no deductible with an HMO as long as you stay in the network. Every doctor visit, the full cost of delivery, the hospital stay, and well-baby care are almost completely covered. (I know someone who paid just \$5 for all her pregnancy care needs!) Because PPOs tend to have a deductible and will make you pay coinsurance on top of that, you'll probably end up paying quite a bit more. On the flip side, if there are any complications that require specialists or a longer hospital stay, a PPO can get pricey, but you may be glad to have a broader range of specialists to choose from.

THE HEALTH CARE OPTION THAT'S GREAT FOR YOUR BOSS (BUT RISKY FOR YOU)

In order to cut costs, some employers have started offering what are called **high-deductible health plans**, which generally offer low premiums but require you to pay more than \$2,000 a year on your own medical bills. At its core, this is just a version of old-fashioned "catastrophic" health insurance that gives you a way to pay the biggest medical bills, but leaves you on your own for everything else. The way it works: You'll have to pay full price for all your basic health care—generally including visits to the doctor or prescription drugs—until you meet that high deductible. Insurance firms save a huge amount of money because they're not picking up these frequent, everyday costs, and they pass on some of the savings